

Ali taking a terrible 10-round TKO beating from Larry Holmes in his penultimate bout.

For Jannik Sinner, the daunting challenge was to keep pace with his more talented archrival, Alcaraz. They had greedily split the last eight Major titles. Indeed, the most frequently asked question heading into the new season was: Can anyone threaten the new Big Two? The 24-year-old Italian was going for his third straight Aussie Open title, on hard courts, his best surface. A bit ominously before the fortnight, Sinner said, "The pressure can be your biggest enemy." Was he still haunted by the three championship points he squandered against Alcaraz in the 2025 French Open final?

Alexander Zverev had a far different goal in mind. Although the 28-year-old German won an Olympic gold medal at the 2021 Tokyo Games and two ATP Finals titles, his resume was missing what he has coveted throughout his 12-year pro career. As the dejected Zverev said after losing his third Grand Slam final 12 months ago — 6-3, 7-6(4), 6-3 to then-No. 1 Sinner — "I don't want to end my career as the best player of all time to never win a Grand Slam, that's for sure. I'll keep doing everything I can to lift one of those trophies."

Alcaraz steamrolled into the fourth round, quashing any doubts he could thrive after splitting last December with Juan Carlos Ferrero. The savvy, seven-year coach gave Alcaraz valuable advice during Major matches, especially about which shot to hit and where to stand.

The more than capable, 56-year-old Samuel López, who joined the team two years ago and split coaching duties with Ferrero in 2025, will be assisted by Alcaraz's older brother Alvaro, a former hitting partner. A year ago, Alcaraz told Punto de Break, "Now he's going to take on more prominence ... He

knows how we operate and how the tour works, and he knows a lot about tennis. Sometimes he has opinions and a way of seeing things that bring a lot to me."

Alcaraz faced his first test against Tommy Paul. The 28-year-old American reached a career-high No. 8 last year, despite a ruptured bone in his foot and a hernia. Highly athletic and versatile, Paul boasted two career wins over the Spaniard and had held serve 38 straight times until the seventh game of the first set. Alcaraz, slightly better in every department, prevailed 7-6(6), 6-4, 7-5.

Next came No. 6-ranked Alex de Minaur, the great Australian men's hope to win its home Slam for the first time since longshot Mark Edmondson 50 years ago. 'Demon' brings terrific speed and competitiveness, but not the size (6', 160 pounds), power and spin to threaten Sincaraz. After the 7-5, 6-2, 6-1 quarterfinal demolition, *Tennis Channel* analyst Mark Petchey raved, "Alcaraz is playing a new way of playing tennis. That was an incredible exhibition to watch."

The ultimate showman

The show wasn't over for Alcaraz. In the post-match interview, Courier asked him to show the crowd his racquet-spinning tricks. With a broad smile, the magician demonstrated three of them. Spectators cheered and applauded as Courier said, "Ladies and gentlemen, he can do it all." Fair to say, Alcaraz needed his entire bag of tricks against Zverev in the semifinal.

In the second quarter of the draw, Zverev dropped

sets to much-improved, 6'8" Canadian Gabriel Diallo, Frenchman Alexandre Muller, and tenacious English lefty Cam Norrie before overpowering Francisco Cerundolo, the No. 18 seed from Argentina, 6-2, 6-4, 6-4. That set up an intriguing quarterfinal with No. 25 Learner Tien.

At age 20, Tien became the youngest American man to make a Grand Slam quarterfinal since Andy Roddick at the 2002 U.S. Open. One measure of his quick progress is that a year ago he upset Daniil Medvedev in a 6-3, 7-6(4), 6-7(8), 1-6, 7-6(7) marathon. This year, the soft-spoken lefty outclassed the former No. 1 and 2021 U.S. Open champion 6-4, 6-0, 6-3, making the voluble 6'6" Russian swallow his first bagel set in 451 played at Grand Slam events.

In another David and Goliath encounter, the 5'11" Tien faced 6'6" Zverev. Size isn't everything, as his 5'9" coach Michael Chang proved when he won the 1989 French Open and ranked No. 2. Tien had a set point in the fourth set before bowing 6-3, 6-7(5), 6-1, 7-6(3).

"Learner [Tien] from the baseline was playing unbelievable," said Zverev. "I don't know what Michael Chang has done with him in the off-season, but it's incredible. Without my 20-something aces, I probably would not have won today." Brad Stine, a USTA national coach who guided Courier to four Major titles, was also impressed, saying, "Learner can be top 10 by the end of the year."

In the bottom quarter of the draw, No. 8 Ben Shelton beat three-time Major runner-up Casper Ruud 3-6, 6-4, 6-3, 6-4. Shelton, one of 25 former or current college players in the main draw — equalling the most at Melbourne since 1989 — won a near-perfect 29 of 30 net points.

Musetti, a stunningly gifted shot-maker, suffered the most heartbreaking defeat of his career against Djokovic. Tennis is the

The wait continues: Djokovic's quest for a 25th Grand Slam title came to an end when he lost an Australian Open final for the first time ever — 2-6, 6-2, 6-3, 7-5 against Alcaraz. GETTY IMAGES

